

Rethinking College

in an Age of Abundant Intelligence

Universities bring together knowledge, expertise, facilities, and people to help students become capable adults and professionals. Many familiar practices developed around real constraints: individual instruction was expensive, access to expertise was limited, and employers expected to train inexperienced graduates.

Those constraints are changing. AI expands what students can learn and accomplish. It also changes what employers expect and what academic work can establish about a student's capability.

The question is how college should respond. Some practices have lost their justification. Others need substantial redesign. Some of the most valuable parts of the university deserve greater emphasis.

The largest opportunity is to reverse the direction of learning: **students obtain knowledge because it serves a purpose they care about, rather than simply because it belongs to a prescribed curriculum.**

Many educators already work this way. The opportunity is to make these approaches central to how the institution operates.

01 Practices to retire

Six inherited practices whose justification has changed

02 Functions to redesign

Five functions with new possibilities

03 Human capabilities and experiences to elevate

Five priorities for a more human education

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PART ONE / RETIRE

Practices to Retire

Some practices solved problems that no longer need to determine the student's experience. The opportunity is to let go of those constraints: a major dictating the learning path, one pace for everyone, and academic outputs standing in for demonstrated capability. Retiring them creates room for higher expectations and an education organized around purpose.

1. Majors

Traditional education

Students choose a major, follow its curriculum, and learn the prescribed body of knowledge. The program determines what comes next, often before students have encountered much of the actual work of their chosen profession.

The answer to “Why do I need to know this?” can become “Because it is part of your major.”

What changed

Personalized guidance and instruction make different learning paths more practical to support. Students can investigate problems across disciplines and receive help identifying and learning what their work requires.

A standardized major is no longer the only way to give an education structure.

The opportunity

Let purpose drive the learning.

Start with something the student cares about accomplishing. Help them discover what they need to understand, learn it, apply it, and use the result to identify the next question.

The student has a reason to seek instruction. Application reveals whether they understand.

Purpose gives them a reason to persist when the learning becomes difficult.

Professional depth and prerequisites remain essential. Educators help students see requirements and connections they would not discover alone. But the major no longer needs to determine the boundaries of the education.

The ambition is that students never have to ask “Why do I need to know this?” because the need is already apparent in what they want to accomplish. When the connection is unclear, helping them see it is the fallback.

The student's purpose creates the demand for knowledge. Learning moves from push to pull.

2. Teaching to the Middle

Traditional education

One teacher delivers material to a group on a common schedule. Students bring different foundations, questions, and learning speeds, but the class has to keep moving.

Some students wait. Others accumulate gaps. The instructional pace is a compromise.

What changed

Individual explanation, practice, and feedback can be available without requiring a separate human instructor for every student. A learner can revisit a prerequisite, request another example, or investigate a deeper question when the need arises.

The opportunity

Let understanding determine the pace.

Students who need more help receive it before confusion becomes a larger obstacle. Students ready to advance can pursue more demanding work. Shared classes can continue without requiring everyone to reach understanding through the same explanations on the same schedule.

The benefit is more time spent on the learning each student needs, with less waiting and fewer unresolved gaps.

3. Research Papers and Routine Assignments

Traditional education

Students gather information, summarize a subject, and submit a competent account of what they found. The paper or exercise serves as evidence that they engaged with the material.

What changed

AI can produce a plausible synthesis or complete many routine exercises with little student involvement. The finished submission may reveal more about the tool's capability than the student's understanding.

The opportunity

Raise the standard from describing a problem to developing a response.

Understand the problem. Propose a solution. Explain why it might work, what assumptions it depends on, and how it could be tested. Then defend it under questioning.

The proposal does not have to be right. It has to offer a novel, thoughtful response that demonstrates applied knowledge. Novelty can be a new application or a considered approach; it need not be a world-first discovery.

Students learn through the attempt, the objections, and the revisions. The weaknesses in their proposal become material for further learning.

4. AI Prohibition

Traditional education

When AI can complete an assignment, one response is to restrict the tool so the existing assignment still works. Students are assessed on work performed without assistance they may be expected to use professionally.

What changed

In an AI-accelerated workplace, employers can expect research, analysis, drafting, and iteration at a different pace. Graduates need practice directing that capability, checking its output, and turning it into useful results.

Avoiding AI throughout college can leave students unprepared for the way they will be expected to work.

The opportunity

Raise expectations to match the professional environment.

Students should use AI to investigate more deeply, consider more alternatives, test assumptions, and produce more substantial work. They should demonstrate that they can deliver with speed, sound judgment, and responsibility for the result.

The standard includes what students accomplish and how effectively they use the capabilities available to them. Specific tasks may still require independent performance, but blanket prohibition cannot serve as the organizing approach to education.

5. Degrees as Proof of Capability

Traditional education

A degree certifies that a student completed a program and met its requirements. Employers use that credential, sometimes supplemented by a GPA, to infer what the graduate knows and can do.

What changed

When AI can complete work used to award a credential, successful completion becomes harder to interpret. If AI can satisfy the requirements, what does the degree establish about the person?

At the same time, learning and working through AI can preserve much richer context: investigations, decisions, contributions, artifacts, failures, corrections, and the people involved. The education can make its own evidence visible as the work happens.

The opportunity

Make capability directly inspectable.

Life has no rubric. Professional situations do not arrive with a complete scoring guide for every judgment that matters. Educational rubrics can help establish standards, but a grade cannot capture the full substance of a person's work.

A graduate should be able to show what they owned, what they built, what they understood, and how they responded when something went wrong. They should be able to apply that capability to a new problem.

Employers gain a stronger basis for judgment. Students gain a way to be recognized for their actual contribution.

Degrees may retain administrative, regulatory, and professional functions. The opportunity is to stop asking the credential alone to carry the burden of proving capability.

6. “Your First Employer Will Teach You That”

Traditional education

College provides the foundations. The first employer supplies much of the experience that turns a beginner into a professional.

Entry-level work funds that development: the beginner produces useful output while learning how to apply their trade.

What changed

AI can perform some of the research, drafting, coding, analysis, and documentation that supported those roles. Where employers need fewer beginners for that output, the opportunity to gain experience through it may shrink.

The developmental need remains, even when the work that financed it changes.

The opportunity

Bring that professional experience into college.

Students can graduate having carried responsibility, worked with other specialists, encountered external constraints, and recovered from failure. They can offer evidence of experience when seeking employment.

If the career starts on rung two, college has to prepare students to reach rung two.

Where the university promises career preparation, its responsibility must move with the starting line.

PART TWO / REDESIGN

Functions to Redesign

Individual instruction, classrooms, departments, facilities, and recruiting still have essential work to do. Their organization can change substantially when students have continuous learning support and a visible history of applying what they learn. The opportunity is to make these functions work together around the student's growing capability.

7. Individual Instruction

Traditional education

Individual instruction is limited by the availability of teachers, tutors, and advisors. Much of the student's work happens between those encounters, with feedback arriving later.

What changed

AI can provide continuing explanations, generate practice, respond to questions, and adapt activities to a student's current understanding. A learning system can preserve context about recurring gaps and explanations that helped.

Providing this well requires educational design and oversight, but it no longer depends entirely on matching every student with a separate human tutor.

The opportunity

Give every student a continuing source of instructional support.

Learners can ask basic questions without embarrassment, revisit difficult material, and receive feedback while working. Instruction can connect directly to their purpose and current application.

Human educators can concentrate their attention where judgment, practical guidance, and sustained personal understanding matter most.

Personal instruction becomes a normal part of the education.

8. Classroom Learning and Evaluation

Traditional education

A class receives a shared explanation and works through a limited set of examples. Evaluation often arrives afterward through a separate test or submission.

Students may spend weeks hearing about a principle while encountering only a narrow range of its applications.

What changed

Students can receive individual support while applying the same principle to different problems. Shared class time can then examine what those applications reveal.

The explanation and defense of the work also give educators opportunities to evaluate understanding directly.

The opportunity

Introduce the principle, let students learn and apply it, then bring their work back to the room.

Twenty students can produce twenty different applications. Each develops one deeply and encounters the reasoning, constraints, and failures behind the others.

They ask what generalizes, what depends on context, and why something worked in one setting but failed in another. An educator can change a condition and ask the student to explain the consequences.

Learning and evaluation become connected. Gaps lead to further investigation, revision, and another demonstration.

The classroom becomes a living library of applications. Students develop understanding by using ideas, explaining them, and seeing how they behave elsewhere.

9. Academic Departments

Traditional education

Departments organize expertise, courses, resources, and professional standards. They also tend to define the boundaries of a student's program and access to other fields.

What changed

Students have more support for investigating unfamiliar subjects and working across disciplines. Their purpose may require combinations of knowledge that do not fit one department's curriculum.

Access to an explanation no longer needs to depend entirely on finding the person assigned to teach that subject.

The opportunity

Make departments concentrations of expertise and resources that students can draw upon.

A student can develop a serious specialty while working with other departments as the problem requires. Departments contribute disciplinary judgment, methods, facilities, and standards without needing to contain the student's entire education.

This makes interdisciplinary work more practical while preserving the depth needed to contribute something dependable.

10. Laboratories, Studios, and Workshops

Traditional education

Access is commonly organized around courses, departmental affiliation, prerequisites, and progression through a program. Students may spend substantial time preparing to use facilities before pursuing work of their own.

Helping a newcomer participate takes time and expertise, which can make wider access difficult to support.

What changed

Individual preparation and mentorship can work together. Students can investigate prerequisites and prepare for practical work with AI support, then collaborate with people who have more experience in the field.

Students developing a specialty also benefit from helping younger students or people from other disciplines. Those collaborators bring new problems and purposes that give the specialist another real application of their trade.

The opportunity

Facilitate access through meaningful collaboration.

Connect newcomers with students and mentors whose growing expertise can help them investigate, experiment, and build. The newcomer gains access and guidance. The more experienced student deepens understanding through explanation and application in an unfamiliar context.

The institution should actively arrange and support these relationships. Appropriate supervision and demonstrated readiness remain part of physical work.

Laboratories, studios, and workshops become places where access, mentorship, and professional development reinforce one another.

11. Career Services and Recruiting

Traditional education

Career services help students translate an education into a résumé, prepare for interviews, and find employers willing to give them an opportunity.

Employers try to infer capability from credentials, brief conversations, and limited examples.

What changed

AI-supported learning can make the process of becoming capable visible. Within a university-supported learning environment, investigations, contributions, decisions, revisions, and collaborations can accumulate as working context throughout the education.

That history is far too rich to fit on a certificate. AI can help organize it into an inspectable account of the student's knowledge, experience, and contribution.

The opportunity

Make recruiting an encounter with demonstrated capability.

Employers can explore the depth of a graduate's experience, inspect relevant work, hear from collaborators, and watch them handle a new challenge. The accumulated context helps people find the evidence that matters to the role; the encounter with the graduate reveals how they use it.

Students can evaluate whether the role fits their purpose, interests, and desired direction. The match becomes more specific on both sides.

Graduates bring an intelligible professional history developed through their education, with appropriate control over what they share.

PART THREE / ELEVATE

Human Capabilities and Experiences to Elevate

The human parts of college become more consequential as intelligence becomes more available. Mentorship, relationships, shared responsibility, community, and creative expression deserve a central place in the educational purpose. The opportunity is to give them the time, support, feedback, and recognition that their importance warrants.

Much of what makes someone dependable, thoughtful, and effective with other people sits outside the formal definition of academic achievement.

These qualities may be praised in a mission statement without receiving comparable attention in teaching, feedback, assessment, or recognition. Their value was always present, but it could seem secondary beside the demanding task of learning a trade.

As access to instruction and intellectual production becomes more abundant, the distinctly human work of building trust, exercising judgment with others, and carrying responsibility deserves greater emphasis.

Human capabilities should count. Collaboration, judgment, communication, and responsibility can be practiced and evaluated through meaningful work. Friendship, belonging, and community deserve institutional support without turning every human experience into a graded activity.

12. Mentorship

Traditional education

Mentorship is valuable but uneven. Access may depend on a student finding the right professor and earning time alongside that person's other responsibilities. Students' ability to mentor one another may be left largely to chance.

What changed

As routine instruction becomes more available individually, human attention can be directed more deliberately toward judgment, practical guidance, and relationships.

Students developing professional depth can also help younger students or people from other disciplines. A collaborator's unfamiliar problem gives them a reason to explain, adapt, and apply their own expertise.

The opportunity

Make mentorship a facilitated, mutually beneficial part of education.

Connect students who need guidance with those developing the relevant expertise, supported by experienced educators and practitioners. This creates a practical route into laboratories, studios, and disciplinary work while giving the mentor further experience applying their trade.

Experienced mentors help students recognize weak assumptions, interpret failure, choose worthwhile problems, and understand the responsibilities their ambitions create.

The institution should arrange these encounters, provide support, and recognize the contribution. Both participants become more capable through the relationship.

13. Relationships and Professional Networks

Traditional education

Relationships are often treated as a benefit of attending college. Students are expected to learn how to build them through experience, extracurricular activities, or their eventual jobs. Their ability to earn trust and sustain a professional relationship may receive little deliberate feedback.

What changed

The value of relationships becomes more visible as learning and routine intellectual production become more available. Knowledge can be retrieved; trust must be developed between people.

Working credibly with another person, understanding their perspective, and sustaining a shared commitment are human capabilities whose importance grows relative to work that can be delegated.

The opportunity

Make relationship-building a practiced and recognized part of education.

Students learn to approach expertise with a clear question, contribute something useful, follow through, and earn trust. Repeated work with peers, faculty, practitioners, and alumni gives those relationships substance.

Feedback can address preparation, listening, reliability, and contribution. Recognition should follow how students work with people, rather than how many contacts they collect.

The context accumulated through AI-supported learning can also make this network visible: whom the student worked with, what they did together, and the expertise each brought. Graduates can see and articulate the professional community they have built over their education.

14. Professional Practice and Teamwork

Traditional education

Students often encounter their most consequential professional responsibilities through an internship, a short capstone, or employment after graduation.

The first job has traditionally taught much of the coordination, reliability, and judgment required to work with other professionals. Group assignments may produce a shared grade without making each person's contribution clear.

What changed

Where the old entry-level training opportunity shrinks, those capabilities still have to develop somewhere. Employers may expect graduates to arrive ready to contribute within a functioning team.

AI-supported work can also preserve the context needed to examine how a student participated: what they owned, who depended on them, and how they responded as the work changed.

The opportunity

Make real responsibility a sustained, assessed part of college.

Through apprenticeships, teams, and functioning organizations, students experience what it means for someone else to depend on them. Technical choices affect budgets. Research affects design. Delays affect colleagues. Disagreements require resolution.

Evaluate how students handle those responsibilities: what they own, how they communicate, what they do when they are wrong, and whether others can depend on them.

Their professional history can connect those contributions to actual collaborators and shared work. Graduates leave with observable evidence of technical capability and professional conduct, along with people who know how they work.

15. Campus Life and Community

Traditional education

Campus life surrounds the formal curriculum: friendships, clubs, shared meals, athletics, unexpected conversations, and living with other young adults.

These experiences can be among the most valuable parts of college, even when they are treated as peripheral to its educational purpose.

What changed

Instruction can increasingly be obtained elsewhere. That makes the value of spending formative years together a more important part of the institution's reason to exist.

Personalized learning does not automatically create belonging, independence, friendship, or community.

The opportunity

Design shared life as part of the education.

Give students places and reasons to meet across disciplines and years, pursue common interests, encounter different perspectives, and build relationships beyond their immediate work.

The campus becomes a setting for becoming an adult among other people. Its value includes encounters and commitments students would struggle to assemble alone.

These experiences deserve resources and attention because of what they contribute to a person's development.

16. Creative and Human Development

Traditional education

Creativity, expression, identity, and ethical reflection can be treated as enrichment around the serious work of acquiring professional knowledge.

An arts requirement can itself feel disconnected from the student's purpose when the institution prescribes the medium without helping the student find a reason to use it.

What changed

Powerful tools expand what a person can produce and make more forms of creative expression approachable. They do not settle what someone wants to express, what an experience should mean, or which outcomes are worth pursuing.

Greater capability makes those human choices more consequential.

The opportunity

Make creative expression part of every student's development, with the student choosing how to express their purpose.

At least one creative practice should belong in the shared educational foundation. It might be drawing, music, writing, performance, design, or another medium. The point is to give form to something the student cares about. That practice can extend into clubs, independent work, and additional arts pursuits.

The ambition is that the student never needs to ask “Why do I need to know this?” because the creative work already serves something they want to express. Helping them discover that connection is the fallback when it is not yet apparent.

Students develop intentional expression, examine consequences, encounter competing perspectives, and refine their own direction. Their growth and choices deserve serious feedback and recognition.

They should graduate with greater capability and a clearer sense of what they care about, how they want to work with others, and what they intend to contribute.

LOOKING AHEAD

A More Human Future for College

Some see these changes as evidence that post-secondary education has become irrelevant. There is truth in that criticism wherever the institution's value depends on distributing the same body of knowledge and certifying its receipt, year after year.

That is a reason to reassess its purpose. It is not a reason to give up on what people can become through an education together.

We have an opportunity to move beyond the credentialing machine and build a modern intellectual commons: a place where people gather around questions worth pursuing, seek knowledge because they need it, and develop understanding through application, conversation, and challenge.

Imagine a university where students arrive with something they care about. They find people who share their curiosity and others whose experience changes how they see the problem. They learn a profession, contribute to one another's work, and attempt things they could not accomplish alone. Knowledge moves between disciplines because the work demands it. An unanswered question becomes an invitation to investigate.

Professors, practitioners, and students participate in that search together. Laboratories open possibilities. Shared work gives relationships substance. Ideas encounter reality early enough to improve. Students leave with the capability to contribute, the judgment to use it, and people with whom they can keep learning and building.

Abundant intelligence gives us room to make this the center of education. As explanation and routine production become more available, we can devote more attention to purpose, curiosity, creativity, trust, and responsibility.

The hopeful future of college is a place where becoming more capable also means becoming more human.